

Mirandês (Mirandese): Linguistic Analysis, Grammar Sketch & Comparative Study

The Last Standing Asturleonese Language in Portugal

1. Introduction

Mirandês (Mirandese) is the only Asturleonese language with official legal recognition in Portugal, granted by Law nº 7/99 of January 29, 1999. It is spoken in the *Tiêrra de Miranda* (Terra de Miranda), a plateau of approximately 500 km² in the extreme northeast of Portugal, Bragança district, bounded by the Douro river to the east (Spanish border) and the Angueira stream to the west and south.

Unlike its nearly extinct "little sisters" — Rionorês (Rio de Onor) and Guadramilês (Guadramil) — Mirandese has a standardized orthography (*Cumbençon Ourtográfica da Lhéngua Mirandesa*, 1999), is taught in schools, has published literature, radio broadcasts, and a dedicated section at the University of Lisbon.

Speaker Demographics (2020)

A study by the University of Vigo (2023 report) found:

- ~3,500 people who know the language
- ~1,500 who speak it regularly
- Severe intergenerational rupture: younger generations associate Mirandese with rurality and poverty
- Predicted extinction in ~20 years at current rates without intervention

The language is in a state of **diglossia** with Portuguese, which dominates formal, educational, and media contexts.

Three Subdialects

Subdialect	Area	Key distinguishing features
Central (normal)	Interior villages of Miranda concelho	Standard diphthongs <i>-iê-</i> , <i>-uô-</i> ; <i>lh-</i> palatalization
Raiano (border)	Villages near the Spanish Zamora frontier	Strongest Castilian influence
Sendinês (meridional)	Vila de Sendim, southern extreme	Monophthongization: <i>-i-</i> , <i>-u-</i> (not <i>-iê-</i> , <i>-uô-</i>); NO <i>lh-</i> palatalization of initial L-

2. Historical Context

2.1 Origin

Mirandese originated in the 6th century CE, part of the same wave of Western Romance varieties that produced Asturian and Leonese in the old kingdoms of Asturias and León. The Terra de Miranda belonged to the Diocese of Astorga (in León), and Leonese missionaries and settlers carried the language into this region. When the territory became politically Portuguese, the Leonese dialect persisted due to extreme geographic isolation — in the 19th century, a coach journey from Porto to Miranda do Douro took 3 days (Leite de Vasconcellos).

2.2 Discovery and Recognition

- **1882:** José Leite de Vasconcellos, a medical student in Porto, discovered the language through a classmate from Duas Igrejas. Published *O dialecto mirandês*.
- **1893:** Vasconcellos published *Carta dialectológica do Continente Português*, the first classification of Portuguese dialects, including Mirandese.
- **1995:** *Proposta de Convenção Ortográfica Mirandesa* published.
- **1999 (January 29):** Law nº 7/99 — Mirandese recognized as Portugal's second official language, approved unanimously by all 230 deputies.
- **1999:** *Convenção Ortográfica da Língua Mirandesa* (definitive edition).
- **2000:** Addendum for Sendinês variety.

2.3 Position within Asturleonese

Mirandese belongs to the **western branch** of the Asturleonese linguistic domain. It is considered the most archaic surviving variety, representing a stage of development earlier than even Western Asturian (*sturiano oucidental*). The key insight from Frías Conde & Quarteu (2002): Mirandese and Asturian are today **two distinct languages** — historically related but separated by centuries of divergent evolution under different state languages (Portuguese vs. Castilian).

The Frías Conde & Quarteu comparative table across four Asturleonese varieties shows Mirandese's unique position:

Feature	Mirandese	Sanabrés	W. Asturian	Central Asturian
Diphthongs	-uô-, -iê-	-uo-, -ie-	-uo-, -ie-	-ue-, -ie-
L- initial	<i>lh-</i> [ʎ]	<i>ll-</i>	<i>l·l-</i>	<i>ll-</i>
-LL- (Lat.)	<i>-lh-</i> [ʎ]	<i>-ll-</i>	<i>-l·l-</i>	<i>-ll-</i>
-NN- (Lat.)	<i>-nh-</i> [ɲ]	<i>-ñ-</i>	<i>-n-</i>	<i>-ñ-</i>
Def. article	<i>l, la, ls, las</i>	<i>el, a, os, as</i>	<i>el, la, los, las</i>	<i>el, la, los, les</i>
Conjugated infinitive	✔ Yes	✗	✗	✗
Neuter gender	✗	✗	✗	✔ Yes
Feminine -AGE	✔ Yes	✗	✗	✗

Two features unique to Mirandese among all Asturleonese:

1. **Conjugated infinitive** — borrowed from Portuguese contact, unknown elsewhere in the domain
2. **Feminine gender for -AGE nouns** — also a Portuguese-contact feature

3. Phonological System

3.1 Vowels (from Belina 2016, with Mirandese phonological chart)

	Anterior	Central	Posterior
Closed	/i/, /ĩ/	/ɨ/, /ĩ/	/u/, /ũ/
Semi-closed	/e/	/ɐ/, /ẽ/	/o/, /õ/
Semi-open	/ɛ/, /ẽ/		/ɔ/
Open		/a/	

Unique Mirandese vowel phoneme: The nasal centralized anterior vowel /ĩ/, represented by ⟨e⟩ in unstressed syllables closed by *n* or *m*: *bendima* [bɨ̃ðime], *sembrado* [sɨ̃βraðu].

3.2 Diphthongs

Mirandese has **18 diphthongs** — an exceptionally rich inventory.

From Latin diphthongs:

Latin	Mirandese	Portuguese	Example
AU →	<i>ou</i> [ow]	<i>ou</i>	<i>paucus</i> → <i>pouco</i>
Æ →	<i>iê</i> [je]	<i>e</i>	<i>cæcum</i> → <i>ciêgo</i> (Pt. <i>cego</i>)
Œ →	<i>e</i> (monophthongized)	<i>e</i>	<i>pœnam</i> → <i>pena</i>

From Latin short vowels (the hallmark Leonese diphthongization):

Latin	Mirandese	Portuguese	Castilian	Examples
Ě [ɛ] →	<i>iê</i> [je]	<i>e/é</i>	<i>ie</i>	<i>piêdra</i> (pedra/piedra), <i>siête</i> (sete/siete), <i>biêlho</i> (velho/viejo), <i>fierro</i> (ferro/hierro)
Ǿ [ɔ] →	<i>uô</i> [wo]	<i>o/ó</i>	<i>ue</i>	<i>ruôda</i> (roda/rueda), <i>fuôro</i> (foro/fuero), <i>puôrta</i> (porta/puerta)

Sendinês exception: These diphthongs reduce to simple vowels: *tirra* (= *tiêrra*), *curpo* (= *cuôrpo*).

Initial unstressed e-/i- → ei- diphthongization (unique Mirandese feature):

Latin	Mirandese	Portuguese	Examples
E-/I- + nasal →	<i>ei-</i> [ej]	<i>e-/i-</i>	<i>eibangelho</i> (evangelho), <i>eisemplo</i> (exemplo), <i>eimigrar</i> (emigrar), <i>eibérico</i> (ibérico), <i>eimaginário</i> (imaginário), <i>heipótese</i> (hipótese)

This diphthongization of initial unstressed vowels before nasals is not found in any other Iberian language.

3.3 Consonants (from Belina 2016, with Mirandese phonological chart)

	Occlusive	Fricative	Affricate	Nasal	Lateral	Tap	Trill
Bilabial	/p/ /b/			/m/			
Labiodental		/f/					
Apico-dental	/t/ /d/	/s/ /z/					
Alveolar		/ɸ/ /ʒ/	/tʃ/	/n/	/l/	/ɾ/	/r/
Palatal		/ʃ/ /ʒ/		/ɲ/	/ʎ/		
Velar					/ʎ/		
	/k/ /g/						

22 consonant phonemes total.

Key distinctive consonant features:

3.3.1 Palatalization of L- (Asturleonese hallmark)

Latin initial L- → /ʎ/, written ⟨lh-⟩:

- *lupum* → **lhobu** (Pt. *lobo*, Sp. *lobo*, Ast. *llobu*)
- *luna* → **lhuna** (Pt. *lua*, Sp. *luna*)
- *liber* → **lhibro** (Pt. *livro*, Sp. *libro*)

Exception: Sendinês does NOT palatalize: *luna*, *lobo*, *libro*.

3.3.2 Betacism (B/V merger)

All historical /v/ merges with /b/. Written ⟨b⟩ in all positions:

- *vacca* → **ba**ca (Pt. *vaca*)
- *iuvenilis* → **jubenil** (Pt. *juvenil*)

3.3.3 The Apico-dental Sibilant Pair /ɸ/ and /ʒ/ (unique in Iberian Peninsula)

Mirandese preserves a **four-way sibilant distinction** not found in any other peninsular language:

Phoneme	Position	Written	Example
/ç/ voiceless alveolar-palatal	initial, after consonant, before voiceless C, word-final	⟨s⟩	<i>spartiçar</i> [ɛptɨ'sɛɾ], <i>farsa</i> [ˈfɑɾɐ], <i>isto</i> [iˈɛtu]
/ʒ/ voiced alveolar- palatal	intervocalic, before voiced C	⟨s⟩, ⟨z⟩	<i>dosa</i> [ˈdɔʒɐ], <i>smolar</i> [ʒmo ˈlaɾ]
/s/ voiceless dental		⟨c⟩ before e/ i, ⟨ç⟩	<i>ciêgo</i> [ˈsjego]
/z/ voiced dental		⟨z⟩	—

The /ç/ vs /s/ distinction is phonemically contrastive: *cuinseilho* [kujˈɕejɫu] ≠ *cuinceilho* [kujˈsejɫu].

The merger of /ʒ/ creates homophones: *coser* [koˈzɛɾ] = *cozer* [koˈzɛɾ].

3.3.4 Nasalization of -ōnis

Latin accusative -ōnis → Mirandese -on [õ] (nasal), distinct from both Portuguese -ão [ẽw̃] and Castilian -ón [on]:

- *leonis* → **lhion** [ˈɫjõ] (Pt. *leão* [liˈẽw])
- *passionis* → **peixon** [pejˈjõ] (Pt. *paixão* [pajˈfẽw])

This nasal ending is claimed to be unique among peninsular languages (Belina 2016).

3.3.5 Intervocalic -d- syncope

Like Rionorês and Guadramilês: *cansado* → **cansado** (retained in standard; syncopated in casual speech as in Portuguese dialects).

3.3.6 Initial i-/e- + nasal → a-

A widespread Mirandese sound change:

- *institutum* → **anstituto**
- *impossibilis* → **ampossible**
- *entonce* → **anton**
- *in+pettia+ar* → **ampeçar**

Exception: *inda* (from Lat. *inde*, cf. Pt. *ainda*).

3.3.7 Latin -ilis retention

Latin words stressed on the penultimate with -ilis ending retain final -e and shift postonic i → e:

- *fossilis* → **fóssele** (Pt. *fóssil*)
- *utilis* → **útele** (Pt. *útil*)
- *facilis* → **fácele** (Pt. *fácil*)

3.3.8 Latin -egalis → -ial

Protonic e → i: *legalis* → **lhial** (Pt. *leal*), *regalis* → **rial** (Pt. *real*).

4. Morphology

4.1 Articles

Definite

	Singular	Plural
Masculine	l	ls
Feminine	la	las

Note: Mirandese uses *l* (not Rionorês *al* or Portuguese *o*). This is the simplest form in the Asturleonese continuum.

Contractions:

Prep. + Art.	Forms	Example
<i>de + l</i>	de l	<i>de l Douro</i>
<i>de + la</i>	de la	<i>de la lhéngua</i>
<i>an + l</i>	ne l	<i>ne l campo</i>
<i>por + l</i>	pul	<i>pul riu</i>
<i>por + la</i>	pula	<i>pula rádio</i>
<i>a + l</i>	al	<i>al redor</i>

Indefinite

	Singular	Plural
Masculine	un	uns
Feminine	ũa	ũas

The feminine *ũa* preserves the nasal tilde, reflecting nasalization from Latin ŪNAM.

4.2 Personal Pronouns

Person	Subject	Complement (direct)	Complement (indirect)
1sg	you	me	me
2sg	tu	te	te
3sg m.	el	lo/le	le
3sg f.	eilha	la	le
1pl	nós	mos	mos
2pl	bós	bos	bos
3pl m.	eilhes	los/les	les
3pl f.	eilhas	las	les

Key features:

- 1sg **you** — Leonese (cf. Guadr. *you*, Rion. *ieu/iou*, Ast. *yo*)
- 1pl complement **mos** — Leonese (cf. Guadr. *mos*, Rion. *nós*)
- 3sg indirect **le** — Leonese (not Pt. *lhe*)

4.3 Possessives (weak/unstressed forms)

Person	Masc.	Fem.
1sg	miu	mie
2sg	tou	tue
3sg	sou	sue
1pl	nuosso	nuossa
2pl	buosso	buossa

Note the Leonese diphthongs in *nuosso/buosso* (from Lat. Ō → uô).

4.4 Demonstratives

Proximity	Mirandese	Portuguese
Near (this)	estes, estas	estes, estas
Middle (that)	esses, essas	esses, essas
Far (that yonder)	aqueilhes, aqueilhas	aqueles, aquelas

4.5 Negation

Nun — the universal Asturleonese negator:

- *Nun ye possible* — "It is not possible"
- *Nun sabiamus ninhum* (Rionorês) — same form

4.6 Adverbs

Mirandese	English	Portuguese	Leonese parallel
anton	then	então	<i>entonce</i>
inda	still, yet	ainda	<i>inda</i>
hoije	today	hoje	<i>hoy</i>
siempre	always	sempre	<i>siempre</i>
tamien	also	também	<i>tamién</i>
subretudo	above all	sobretudo	—
sólo	only	só	<i>solo</i>
bien	well	bem	<i>bien</i>

4.7 Key Prepositions

Mirandese	English	Portuguese
an	in	em
cun	with	com
zde	since, from	desde
hasta	until	até
para	to, for	para
pul/pula	through/by the	pelo/pela
drento	inside	dentro

4.8 Verb Morphology (sketch)

Mirandese verbs follow three conjugation classes (-ar, -er, -ir) with Leonese morphology plus the **conjugated infinitive** (unique among all Asturleonese):

Conjugated Infinitive (Portuguese-contact innovation)

Person	Example (<i>falar</i>)
1sg	<i>para you falar</i>
3sg	<i>para el falar</i>
1pl	<i>para nós falarmos</i>
3pl	<i>para eilhes falaren</i>

This feature exists in no other Asturleonese variety — it was adopted from Portuguese.

Present Indicative of TENER (to have)

Person	Mirandese	Portuguese	Castilian
1sg	tengo	tenho	tengo
2sg	tienes	tens	tienes
3sg	tien	tem	tiene
1pl	tenemos	temos	tenemos
2pl	teneis	tendes	tenéis
3pl	tiénen	têm	tienen

Present Indicative of SER (to be)

Person	Mirandese	Portuguese	Castilian
1sg	sou	sou	soy
2sg	yes	és	eres
3sg	ye	é	es
1pl	somos	somos	somos
2pl	sois	sois	sois
3pl	son	são	son

Note: The 3sg ye is the quintessential Asturleonese copula (cf. Asturian ye).

Imperfect Indicative patterns

Conjugation	3sg	3pl	Portuguese equiv.
1st (-ar)	-aba	-ában	-ava / -avam
2nd (-er)	-ie	-ien	-ia / -iam
3rd (-ir)	-ie	-ien	-ia / -iam

Preterite 3pl endings

As in Rionorês and Guadramilês, the 3pl preterite ends in nasalized forms:

- ampeçórun* (começaram), *aparecírun* (apareceram), *fúrun* (foram)
- tubírun* (tiveram), *quedássen* (ficassem)

5. Orthographic System

The *Cumbeçon Ourtográfica da Lhéngua Mirandesa* (1999, revised 2000) established a Portuguese-influenced but autonomous system:

Key Orthographic Conventions

Convention	Mirandese	Portuguese	Rationale
lh- initial	<i>lhobu, lhuna, lhibro</i>	<i>lobo, lua, livro</i>	Marks Leonese L-palatalization
b for all b/v	<i>bacha, bida, bolber</i>	<i>vaca, vida, voltar</i>	Reflects betacism
-iê- diphthong	<i>piêdra, tiêrra, fiêrro</i>	<i>pedra, terra, ferro</i>	Marks Leonese Ě diphthong
-uô- diphthong	<i>puôrta, fuôro, ruôda</i>	<i>porta, foro, roda</i>	Marks Leonese Ů diphthong
ei- initial	<i>eibangelho, eisemplo</i>	<i>evangelho, exemplo</i>	Unique Mirandese diphthong
nh for -NN-	<i>anho, banho</i>	<i>ano, banho</i>	Marks Leonese geminate nasalization
-çon ending	<i>naçon, oufecializaçon</i>	<i>nação, oficialização</i>	Mirandese nasal [õ] not Pt. [ẽw̃]
nun	<i>nun ye</i>	<i>não é</i>	Leonese negator
l/la/ls/las	articles	<i>o/a/os/as</i>	Leonese articles

Sendinês Adaptations (2000 addendum)

- Diphthongs *-iê-* and *-uô-* written as *-ie-* and *-uo-* (reflecting monophthongized pronunciation)
- Initial L- NOT palatalized: *luna* (not *lhuna*), *lobo* (not *lhobu*)

6. Comparative Lexicon: The Three Portuguese Asturleonese Varieties

English	Mirandese	Rionorês	Guadramilês	Portuguese
bread	pan	<i>pan</i>	<i>pan</i>	pão
moon	lhuna	—	<i>lhuna</i>	lua
wolf	lhobu	—	—	lobo
stone	piêdra	<i>pedra</i>	—	pedra
door	puôrta	<i>puârta</i>	—	porta
bridge	puonte	<i>puonte</i>	—	ponte
dead	muôrto	<i>muartu</i>	—	morto
strength	fuôrça	<i>fuarça</i>	—	força
wheel	ruôda	<i>ruôdra</i>	—	roda
eye	uôlho	—	<i>uolho</i>	olho
seven	siête	—	—	sete
old (man)	biêlho	—	—	velho
feast	fiesta	—	<i>fiesta</i>	festa
hand	mano	<i>man</i>	<i>mã</i>	mão
I (pronoun)	you	<i>ieu/iou</i>	<i>you</i>	eu
he	el	<i>iêl</i>	<i>el</i>	ele
not	nun	<i>nun</i>	<i>nun/num</i>	não
with	cun	<i>cun</i>	<i>cun</i>	com
until	hasta	<i>hasta/asté</i>	<i>atá</i>	até
also	tamien	<i>tambien</i>	<i>tamien</i>	também
the (m.sg.)	l	<i>al</i>	<i>o</i>	o
the (f.sg.)	la	<i>a/la</i>	<i>la/a</i>	a
the (m.pl.)	ls	<i>los</i>	—	os
the (f.pl.)	las	<i>las</i>	<i>las</i>	as
to call	chamar	<i>tchamar</i> [tʃ]	<i>chamar</i> [ʃ]	chamar
to say	dezir	<i>decir/dixir</i>	<i>dezir</i>	dizer
eight	oito	<i>otcho</i> [tʃ]	—	oito

cow	 Baca	<i> Baca</i>	—	vaca
already	 yá	—	<i> yá</i>	já
still/yet	 inda	—	<i> inda</i>	ainda

7. The Modern Lexicon Problem: Roof Languages

One of the most important observations from Frías Conde & Quarteu (2002) is the **roof language** (*lhéngua teito*) effect. Modern vocabulary enters Mirandese from Portuguese and Asturian from Castilian, reproducing the Portuguese–Spanish lexical divide:

Portuguese	Mirandese	Asturian	Castilian
autocarro	 autocarro	autobús	autobús
barragem	 barraige	embalse	embalse
câmara municipal	 cámara municipal	a(y)untamientu	ayuntamiento
comboio	 comboio	tren	tren
computador	 cumputador	ordenador	ordenador
estrada	 strada	carretera	carretera
faca	 faca	cuchiellu	cuchillo
garfo	 garfo	tenedor	tenedor
garrafa	 garrafa	botella	botella
rua	 rue	cai/caye	calle

This lexical divergence is the strongest evidence that Mirandese and Asturian, despite shared origins, function as **two separate modern languages**.

8. Comprehensive Feature Comparison: All Three Portuguese Asturleonese Varieties

Feature	Mirandese	Rionorês	Guadramilês	Status
Speakers	~1,500 regular	~0–5 active	~0–5 active	—
Official status	✅ Law 7/99	❌ None	❌ None	—
Standardized orthography	✅ 1999	❌ None	❌ None	—
Taught in schools	✅ Optional	❌	❌	—
Published literature	✅ Multiple books	❌	❌	—
M. article	<i>l</i>	<i>al</i>	<i>o</i> (Pt.)	Rion. most archaic
F. article	<i>la</i>	<i>a/la</i>	<i>la/a</i>	—
Betacism	✅	✅	✅	Universal
L- palatalization	✅ <i>lh-</i>	unclear	✅ <i>lh-</i>	Sendinês lacks it
Affricate [tʃ]	✅ (PL-, CL-, FL-)	✅ (<i>tchamar</i>)	❌	Guadr. lost it
Ë → iê	✅ <i>piêdra</i>	✅ <i>piedra</i>	✅ <i>fiesta</i>	Universal
Ö → uô	✅ <i>puôrta</i>	✅ <i>puârta</i>	✅ <i>almuorço</i>	Universal
Initial ei-	✅ <i>eibangelho</i>	❌	❌	Unique to Mirandese
4-way sibilants	✅ /s z ʒ ʒ/	❌	❌	Unique to Mirandese
-õnis → -on [õ]	✅ <i>lhion</i>	❌ (data lacking)	❌ (data lacking)	Unique to Mirandese
Conjugated infinitive	✅	❌	❌	Pt. contact innovation
Imperfect -aba	✅	✅	✅	Universal
3pl in -n	✅ - <i>órun</i>	✅ - <i>anun</i>	✅ - <i>ában</i>	Universal
nun (negation)	✅	✅	✅	Universal
pan (bread)	✅	✅	✅	Universal
you (I)	✅	✅ (<i>ieu/iou</i>)	✅	Universal
Portuguese contamination	Moderate (lexical)	High (phonological)	Very high	Gradient

9. Sample Text with Analysis

From Amadeu Ferreira (Público, 2007):

Muitas lhénguas ténen proua de ls sous pergaminos antigos, de la lhiteratura screbida hai cientos d'anhos i de scritores hai muito afamados, hoije bandeiras dessas lhénguas. Mas outras hai que nun puoden tener proua de nada desso, cumo ye l causo de la lhéngua mirandesa.

Interlinear gloss:

Mirandese	Portuguese	English
Muitas lhénguas	Muitas línguas	Many languages
ténen proua	têm orgulho	have pride
de ls sous pergaminos antigos	dos seus pergaminhos antigos	of their ancient parchments
de la lhiteratura screbida	da literatura escrita	of the literature written
hai cientos d'anhos	há centenas de anos	hundreds of years ago
i de scritores hai muito afamados	e de escritores muito famosos	and of very famous writers
hoije bandeiras dessas lhénguas	hoje bandeiras dessas línguas	today banners of those languages
Mas outras hai	Mas há outras	But there are others
que nun puoden tener proua	que não podem ter orgulho	that cannot have pride
de nada desso	de nada disso	of any of that
cumo ye l causo	como é o caso	as is the case
de la lhéngua mirandesa	da língua mirandesa	of the Mirandese language

Observable features in this passage alone: *lh-* palatalization (*lhénguas*, *lhiteratura*), Leonese article (*la*, *ls*, *l*), betacism (*screbida*), *ye* copula, **nun** negation, **hai** existential, *-on* nasal ending (*proua*, though here *causo*), Portuguese-derived vocabulary (*bandeiras*, *pergaminos*), and the characteristic Mirandese *ei-* in *cientos* from *centum*.

10. IPA Transcription of Key Mirandese Words

Mirandese	IPA	English	Portuguese
lhéngua	[ˈʎɛŋɡwɐ]	language	língua
lhobu	[ˈʎobu]	wolf	lobo
lhuna	[ˈʎunɐ]	moon	lua
lhibro	[ˈʎibɾu]	book	livro
piêdra	[ˈpjɛdɾɐ]	stone	pedra
siête	[ˈsjɛtɐ]	seven	sete
biêlho	[ˈbjɛʎu]	old man	velho
puôrta	[ˈpwɔɾtɐ]	door	porta
ruôda	[ˈrwodɐ]	wheel	roda
fuôro	[ˈfworu]	charter/law	foro
lhion	[ˈʎjõ]	lion	leão
peixon	[pejˈʃõ]	passion	paixão
eibangelho	[ejbɛˈʒɛʎu]	gospel	evangelho
eisemplo	[ejˈzẽplu]	example	exemplo
anstituto	[ẽɛtiˈtutu]	institute	instituto
ampossible	[ẽpoˈɛiblɐ]	impossible	impossível
baca	[ˈbakɐ]	cow	vaca
anton	[ẽˈtõ]	then	então
nun	[nũ]	not	não
you	[jow]	I	eu
cun	[kũ]	with	com
ye	[jɐ]	is (3sg)	é
pan	[pẽ]	bread	pão
rue	[ˈrue]	street	rua
fácele	[ˈfɛɛle]	easy	fácil
útele	[ˈuɛɛle]	useful	útil
chamar	[tʃɐˈmar]	to call	chamar

11. Sociolinguistic Situation

The Shame Factor

Both Rionorês and Guadramilês speakers expressed embarrassment about their dialects. For Mirandese, this was historically the primary threat: the arrival of radio, television, and compulsory Portuguese schooling made speakers feel they were "speaking bad Portuguese." The Rionorês term *quando solos* ("when alone") applies equally to Mirandese: speakers only used it in intimate, familiar contexts.

The construction of Portuguese dams on the Douro brought thousands of workers from other regions who mocked Mirandese speakers, calling them *palhantres* — a term implying they couldn't speak either Portuguese or Castilian properly, but only a degraded mixture.

The Turning Point

Official recognition in 1999 gave Mirandese "a new soul" (*ũa alma nuoba*). Publishing, radio, music (including the rock band *Picã Tumilho* from Sendim), and institutional use have slowly reversed the stigma, though the 2020 Vigo study shows the reversal is not fast enough.

The Unresolved Paradox

As Frías Conde & Quarteu note: while Mirandese (with ~1,500 active speakers) has official state recognition, Asturian in Spain (with ~100,000+ speakers) still lacks it, even in its own autonomous community. This is both an encouragement and a warning about the fragility of minority language survival.

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Analysis prepared from Belina (2016), Frías Conde & Quarteu (2002), Wikipedia (Portuguese edition, accessed 2026), and comparative data from the Guadramilês and Rionorês analyses in this series.